

Chapter 65-1

Liang Shi's right hand caressed the silver bracelet on her left wrist. The patterns on it were intricate, and she could feel the texture with her fingernails.

It was clearly a piece of silver jewelry that should seem out of place in this era, yet it still looked elegant and beautiful.

Even colleagues in the office had once complimented her on this bracelet, saying it was more delicate than many silver pieces made nowadays.

It was indeed an exquisite antique craft piece.

Silver jewelry becomes brighter the more you wear it, and clearer the more you polish it.

This bracelet on Liang Shi's wrist was much brighter than before.

Although she and the woman were now facing each other directly, the woman still didn't remove her sunglasses and only nodded slightly toward her.

Yet Liang Shi subconsciously covered the silver bracelet on her wrist.

After a while, Su Yu, accompanied by the woman, came over to greet Rainbow. "Zhou Caihong, have you finished your handicraft homework?"

Rainbow furrowed her brows slightly. "School just ended..."

"I finished mine already." Su Yu said, "My mom drew the template for me, and I quickly cut it out."

"Oh." Rainbow praised without any emotion, "Your mom is really amazing."

Su Yu: "...?"

Not receiving the praise she had anticipated, her little face fell, and she huffed lightly. "You're really no fun."

As soon as she finished speaking, the woman lightly patted her shoulder. "A-Yu, you can't be rude."

"Mmm~" Su Yu whimpered aggrievedly.

The woman then apologized to Rainbow on Su Yu's behalf. "I'm sorry, little Caihong. Su Yu speaks without thinking."

"It's okay, Auntie." Rainbow smiled obediently, but her words were particularly cutting. "She's like this at kindergarten too."

The woman's expression changed slightly, her tone becoming somewhat awkward. "Then I'm really sorry."

"It's fine. Kids, you know, they all love to show off." Rainbow said with an air of composed wisdom.¹

Liang Shi sat to the side listening, helplessly covering her forehead. If she were to have a daughter like Rainbow in the future, she really wouldn't know how to raise her. Currently, it seemed Zhou Li's approach was the most straightforward and effective—just let her develop freely and do whatever she likes.

Hearing this, the woman didn't show the mocking or disdainful look that ordinary adults would have. Instead, she became interested and asked her gently, "What about you? Don't you like to show off?"

Rainbow was silent for two seconds. "Occasionally."

Liang Shi: "..."

This child Rainbow had a very big advantage—she faced her inner self honestly.

It was probably the childlike nature still preserved in her bones; no matter how high her IQ, it would never completely disappear.

And she could achieve a level of honesty that eighty percent of adults couldn't.

"Mom, look." Before the woman could say anything more, Su Yu couldn't wait to tattle. "She's always like this."

As Su Yu spoke, she began to imitate, mimicking Rainbow's tone: "It's fine, whatever's fine, okay, thank you, no need, I don't like it."

Liang Shi listened from the side and couldn't help but glance over at Rainbow.

She saw Rainbow frowning, lips pressed together, looking deeply resentful, as if she was contemplating whether or not to interrupt this "parroting" act in front of the other person's mother.

Fortunately, before Rainbow's patience ran out, Su Yu stopped.

Su Yu also had a little-adult demeanor, crossing her arms and looking at Rainbow. "Zhou Caihong, are you very angry?"

The paper cup in Rainbow's hand was nearly crushed, but she glanced at the woman beside Su Yu and practically ground out through her teeth, "No."

"See." Su Yu said again, "She's like this every day. Being deskmates with her is really..."

Su Yu looked up at the sky. "So bori—"

Before she could finish saying "boring," her forehead was smacked by the woman.

Su Yu immediately looked stunned, blinking her eyes. That delicate face like carved jade—one that would make anyone feel three parts of tender affection upon seeing it—instantly fell, looking extremely aggrieved. "Mom!"

"What?" The woman stood there, hands stuffed into her coat pockets, as if to prevent any attempts at acting cute. She looked sternly at Su Yu. "Apologize to your deskmate."

Su Yu pouted. "I won't."

"If you apologize to your deskmate, I'll apologize to you," the woman said.

Su Yu hesitated and began to think it over.

"It's not necessary, Auntie." Rainbow spoke up first. "She's always like this. I'm used to it."

The woman's face was full of embarrassment.

After a long while, she sighed helplessly. "I often hear Su Yu mention you. She says you're very smart. Now that I've met you, you're indeed extraordinary."

After saying this, she paused. "I'm sorry, you're acting so mature that I can't help but speak formally to you. I was just complimenting you..."

"It's okay, I understand." Rainbow took a sip of cola and waited until she swallowed before saying, "You're complimenting me for being unusual."

Rainbow had received too many compliments since she was little.

This bit from the woman was merely a drop in the bucket² for her.

After a brief moment of surprise, the woman finally couldn't help but turn her gaze to the only adult at the table.

Looking at Liang Shi, she couldn't help but exclaim, "You've raised your daughter really well."

Liang Shi, who had been sitting there eating melon and watching the show³: "?"

Liang Shi looked confused, then finally reacted. She and Rainbow denied it almost in unison.

"I'm not her mother."

"She's not my mother."

After speaking, the two made eye contact. Rainbow shrugged helplessly, then lowered her head to continue eating.

"Huh?" It was the woman who was left stunned instead.

Footnotes:

¹ "老神在在" (lǎo shén zài zài) - A Chinese expression describing someone who appears calm, composed, and unperturbed, often with an air of knowing wisdom beyond their years. Here it emphasizes how Rainbow speaks with a maturity unusual for her age.

² "九牛一毛" (jiǔ niú yī máo) - Literally "a single hair from nine oxen," this is a Chinese idiom meaning something extremely insignificant or a tiny fraction of the whole.

³ "吃瓜看戲" (chī guā kàn xì) - Literally "eating melon and watching a show," this is Chinese internet slang for being a bystander/spectator watching drama unfold, similar to "watching from the sidelines" or being a casual observer of entertaining events. The "eating melon" part comes from the image of someone munching on watermelon seeds while watching something interesting happen.

Chapter 65-2

Liang Shi pulled her sleeve down slightly, covering the silver bracelet on her left wrist. She stood up and extended her right hand to introduce herself to the woman. "Hello, I'm Liang Shi, a colleague of little friend Zhou Caihong's mother."

When she said it, she deliberately emphasized the words "little friend."

It really wasn't that she kept forgetting.

It was just that Rainbow's words and actions didn't seem like those of a child.

Many adults, when communicating with her, often forgot that she was only five years old.

The woman extended her hand and shook hers. "Hello, Su Yu's mother, Su Mu."

As soon as she finished speaking, Ling Dang asked in confusion from the side, "Auntie, why is she called Su Yu? I heard from Shen Yiran that her name is Sheng Yu."

Hearing these two characters, the woman's eyelashes trembled slightly.

It was a very subtle change, but for Liang Shi, who had been observing the other party with full attention since she walked in, this small change didn't escape her eyes.

At the same time, Liang Shi mentally gave Ling Dang a thumbs up.

She was simply a divine assist.

Su Yu, Sheng Yu.

One person with two names, and completely unrelated surnames at that.

The Su Mu before her was obviously Su Yao.

The saying "time never defeats a beauty" was perfectly embodied in her.

Her appearance hadn't changed much.

Su Yu huffed, "Why can't I be called Su Yu? I have two names—is that not allowed?!"

"It's allowed, it's allowed." Ling Dang also huffed. "I was just curious. Why are you being so fierce?"

Su Yu: "...I'm just fierce! Bleh bleh bleh!¹ You actually play with Shen Yiran—you're not a good person!"

At the mention of Shen Yiran, Ling Dang became energized. She stood up, but was only about as tall as the table, making her look completely lacking in presence. So she used both hands and feet to climb onto the sofa.

She had some difficulty climbing up herself, and it was Rainbow who secretly lent a helping hand, giving her a boost.

None of these small movements escaped Liang Shi's eyes. She just felt her head aching.

Ling Dang glared at Su Yu, hands on her hips. "So what if I play with Shen Yiran? She's so pretty! I just like playing with her. You're the one who's not a good person! Only bad people have a bunch of nicknames! Just like Xiong Ba Ge!"²

Liang Shi: "?"

Who?

She was completely confused.

But Su Yu understood instantly. "You're the Xiong Ba Ge!"

Seeing that the two were about to start arguing, Liang Shi immediately went to lift Ling Dang down from the sofa. She smiled awkwardly at Su Mu and said, "I'm sorry, Ling Dang has a bit of a quick temper."

"It's fine, your daughter is very cute." Su Mu smiled. "It's mine who's too naughty."

Liang Shi: "..."

She was embarrassed again. "This isn't my daughter either."

Su Mu was surprised. "Huh?"

Liang Shi explained helplessly, "This is my niece."

Su Mu: "...Oh."

From that rapidly descending tone, one could hear Su Mu's confusion.

Liang Shi also realized for the first time that in other people's eyes, she was already someone who could have daughters this big!

But... raising children was so exhausting.

She had truly experienced this firsthand now.

After soothing Ling Dang on this side, Su Yu was throwing a tantrum on the other side, looking all puffed up with anger.

But Su Mu didn't pay it any attention. She just looked at Ling Dang and said, "Little friend, it's not only bad people who have two names. Moon White Rabbit also has another name called Frost Flower, right?"³

Liang Shi knew about Moon White Rabbit.

It was from the animated series "Rabbit Don't Cry."

It seemed like the argument between Ling Dang and Su Yu just now was also about this animated series.

Liang Shi felt that she wasn't exactly out of touch with the times—at most, she just wasn't keeping up with children's pace.

Su Mu patiently explained to Ling Dang, "Su Yu has two names because her dad and I each gave her one, so she has two."

Seeing that Su Mu's attitude was so nice, Ling Dang immediately apologized awkwardly. "I'm sorry, Auntie. I didn't mean to say that."

"I know." Su Mu smiled gently, then crouched down to look at Su Yu. "A-Yu, don't you think you should say something too?"

Being closer this time, Liang Shi could see her profile from this angle.

Under the dark blue coat was a light gray knit sweater, loose and baggy.

Su Mu was thin, with delicate collarbones. She wore a silver necklace around her neck. Looking from the side, one could vaguely see something like a tattoo to the right of her collarbone, but it was covered by her clothes and couldn't be seen clearly.

Liang Shi could only half-guess.

Footnotes:

¹ "略略略" (lüè lüè lüè) - A childish taunting sound in Chinese, similar to sticking out one's tongue and making a "bleh" or "nyah nyah" sound to mock someone.

² "熊巴哥" (Xiong Ba Ge) - This appears to be a character reference, likely a villain from a children's show or cartoon who is known by multiple names/aliases. The name literally could mean "Brother Bear Ba." Given the context about only bad people having multiple nicknames, this is likely a villain character the children know from media.

³ "Moon White Rabbit" and "Frost Flower" - Characters from a fictional animated series called "Rabbit Don't Cry" (兔子不哭) mentioned in the story. Su Mu uses this example to explain to Ling Dang that having two names doesn't make someone bad.

Chapter 65-3

After Su Mu finished educating the two children, both sides apologized to each other and made up again.

Only then did Liang Shi speak up. "So which one is the little friend's formal name?"

"It's Su Yu," Su Mu said. "She takes my surname."

Liang Shi nodded, then added, "Sorry, that was a bit abrupt of me. I was just curious after hearing all that."

"It's fine." Su Mu smiled gently. "You're very good with children. They're both very well-behaved."

"Their parents raised them well." Liang Shi didn't dare take credit.

The time she had spent with these two little ones wasn't long.

It could only be said that they were self-disciplined.

"Your necklace is very beautiful." Liang Shi said, "May I politely ask where you bought it?"

Su Mu's smile paused. "It was designed by my husband."

"Ah." Liang Shi felt quite disappointed. "So that means it's not available for purchase."

At the mention of her husband, Su Mu's mood visibly dampened, dropping almost instantly. She responded very softly, "Mm."

"Is your husband a jewelry designer?" Liang Shi asked. "Can I buy products he designed on the market? I really love this style."

Su Mu paused again.

After a long while, she said gently, "He's not."

She wouldn't say anything more than that.

Liang Shi wanted to get more information out of her, but Su Mu was measured in her words and kept her mouth tightly shut.

When the other party was about to leave, Liang Shi stopped being subtle and said directly, "Do you know Su Yao?"

Upon hearing this name, Su Mu pressed her lips together. "Hm?"

"You look somewhat like her." Liang Shi said, "My wife is in the jewelry industry and really admires Su Yao. She often mentions her at home. So when I saw you, I thought of her. I was wondering if you..."

"Not familiar. Don't know her." Su Mu said coldly. "Sorry, we have things to do. We'll be leaving first."

The evasive emotions were obvious.

After saying this, she took Su Yu to the counter to pick up their order, then hurried away.

Liang Shi watched their departing figures through the window.

If she had been slightly uncertain before, thinking that Su Mu might be Su Yao's twin sister or something, she was now one hundred percent certain that Su Mu was Su Yao.

When this name was mentioned, her evasive attitude and nervous emotions had given her away completely.

But why did she change her name?

And moreover... she wouldn't even acknowledge her former identity.

Su Mu, Su Yao...

Su Yu, Sheng Yu...

Just as Liang Shi was thinking carefully, trying to sort out the connections between them, Rainbow suddenly said with envy, "That auntie's tattoo was so cool."

Liang Shi was surprised. "You saw her tattoo?"

"Yeah." Rainbow said, "It was some trees, but they looked so lifelike, like they were swaying in the wind."

A row of trees?

"There were words under the trees too." Rainbow said, "But I didn't see them clearly. Those trees were really pretty though. When I grow up, I want to get one too."

Ling Dang chimed in, "I saw it clearly!"

Liang Shi: "??"

Were children's eyesight this good?!

Though their seating position was indeed better for seeing it.

Ling Dang seemed proud that she could one-up Rainbow for once, and said smugly, "It was the character 'Lin'—double-wood Lin."¹

Lin...

A row of trees...

A row of trees is a forest—a lin!²

Liang Shi's eyes lit up, suddenly feeling enlightened!

So Su Mu had tattooed Sheng Qinglin on her collarbone.

Su Mu—

Taking one half each from "Qing" and "Lin" creates "Mu."³

Sheng Qinglin died unexpectedly, and for this, Su Yao didn't hesitate to change her name. Her whole person now lived carrying his mark.

Then what about Sheng Yu?

When Su Mu called her daughter, she still called her "A-Yu."

This showed that deep down, she preferred the name Sheng Yu.

Footnotes:

¹ The Chinese character "林" (lín) meaning "forest" or "woods" is composed of two "木" (mù, meaning "wood" or "tree") characters side by side, hence "double-wood Lin."

² This is a play on how Chinese characters are formed. A single tree is "木" (mù), and when you put two trees together "林" (lín), it means a grove or forest. Liang Shi realizes the tattoo of trees represents the character "林" (Lin) from Sheng Qinglin's name.

³ The name "沐" (Mù) is formed by combining elements from "清" (Qīng) and "林" (Lín). Specifically, the water radical "氵" from "清" combined with "木" (wood) from "林" creates "沐" (mù), which means "to bathe" or "to wash." This is Su Yao's way of keeping Sheng Qinglin's memory alive through her new name "Su Mu."

Chapter 65-4

Liang Shi asked Ling Dang again, "Ling Dang, why does Shen Yiran know that Su Yu is called Sheng Yu?"

Ling Dang frowned, thought for a while, and then said, "Shen Yiran said they grew up together. She also said Sheng Yu used to steal her milk to drink when they were little."

Sheng Yu was once fostered at Shen Yiran's home?

"Then what does Shen Yiran's family do? Do you know?" Liang Shi asked again.

She felt like she had sent two little spies into the kindergarten.

The information these two little friends had seemed useless on the surface, but when connected together, it formed a complete thread.

The kindergarten that Ling Dang attended was filled with children who were either wealthy or from prestigious families.

And Shen Yiran's surname was Shen—could she be related to the well-known Shen family in Haizhou City?

Ling Dang shook her head. "I don't know. Anyway, they're very poor."

Liang Shi: "?"

"Why are they very poor?" Liang Shi asked.

Ling Dang said matter-of-factly, "Their family of four lives in an apartment of just over a hundred square meters.¹ Isn't that poor? Apparently her dad gambled away a lot of money, and then offended his cousin..."

Ling Dang paused. "I don't remember what relative it was. Then they got kicked out of their villa. She even cried in class about it last year."

Liang Shi was surprised. "You still remember something from last year?"

"Of course!" Ling Dang puffed out her chest proudly. "I have a great memory! Besides, it was about Shen Yiran! Of course I have to remember. I'm going to tell her about it when we get married someday."

Liang Shi: "..."

How very ambitious of her.

Even Rainbow couldn't help but let out a soft scoff.

Ling Dang: "?"

She huffed lightly. "None of you understand me. Hmph!"

"Alright." Liang Shi pushed the hamburger in front of her and pinched her nose. "Little piggy, if you keep huffing, you're going to turn into a little pig head. Hurry up and eat, or it'll get cold and upset your tummy."

Ling Dang was pinched until she was whimpering, then started playing around with her.

Usually, meals at the old residence were very proper and mannered. But now she insisted on sitting next to Liang Shi, acting spoiled and wanting to be held—she would only eat while being held.

Liang Shi had no choice but to hold her, being watched by Rainbow across the table with an extremely complicated look, as if to say—This works too? How childish.

But Liang Shi felt she couldn't favor one over the other, so she asked Rainbow, "Do you want to come over too?"

Rainbow shook her head rapidly. "Can't fit."

Ling Dang, who had been happily eating her hamburger, froze mid-bite. Her little eyes went round as she questioned, "Are you calling me fat?"

Rainbow: "No."

"Yes you are!"

"No."

"..."

A new round of childish battle began. Liang Shi drew in a sharp breath and stuffed the hamburger into Ling Dang's mouth.

Ling Dang: "Nom~"

The war finally ceased.

Liang Shi looked at the two of them and suddenly thought—in the future, it would be better to just have one child.

Two children would argue non-stop.

Footnotes:

¹ "Over a hundred square meters" - In China, apartment sizes are measured in square meters. An apartment of 100+ square meters (approximately 1,000+ square feet) would be considered modest or small for a wealthy family, especially compared to living in a villa. For context, affluent families in major Chinese cities often live in much larger properties, so Ling Dang's childish perspective considers this "poor" relative to her own privileged upbringing.

Chapter 65-5

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That evening, Liang Shi sent Rainbow back to her home. When she saw Zhou Li, the other woman gave her a box of fresh strawberries.

They were large, juicy, and bright red—they looked delicious.

Ling Dang sat in the car staring at the strawberries. She first said she wanted to save them for her aunt, but then remembered, "Auntie, isn't Auntie unable to eat strawberries?"

"She can't even look at them." Liang Shi said, "So you need to finish them before we get home."

Ling Dang touched her already round and full tummy. "But I can't finish them all."

"We'll share." Liang Shi drove back to Shallow Water Bay but didn't get out of the car. She just sat in the car with Ling Dang, sharing the strawberries.

Ling Dang kept saying she couldn't eat anymore, but then couldn't help saying, "These are really yummy."

Liang Shi thought she was being dramatic. A child like Ling Dang—what hadn't she eaten before?

She raised an eyebrow. "Maybe it's because they're from someone else's house, so they taste extra good?"

Ling Dang nodded, her eyes showing a hint of mischief. "I think Rainbow's mom is so gentle, just like my mom."

Liang Shi didn't understand her sudden change of topic. "So?"

Ling Dang giggled. "Then why is Rainbow so stuffy while I'm so cute?"

Liang Shi: "..."

When she said this, there wasn't any malice—it seemed like teasing, and also like acting cute and playful.

Her eyes curved into crescents, just like the moon in the sky—absolutely adorable.

Liang Shi felt both helpless and like her heart was about to melt.

She couldn't even think of how to respond to that.

What Xu Qingzhu saw when she pushed open the door was Liang Shi helplessly yet dotingly lifting Ling Dang out of the car, then tapping her nose. "You've really got me beat."

Said with complete sincerity.

Xu Qingzhu had changed into loungewear—a long slip dress with a long cardigan over it. The silver necklace around her neck glittered under the dim yellow light. Her hair was casually tied up, very loose, looking languid and casual.

She leaned against the doorframe, arms crossed, the corners of her mouth unable to help but curve upward.

The moment Ling Dang saw her, she immediately waved. "Auntie!"

Xu Qingzhu greeted her back. "Long time no see, little Ling Dang."

Liang Shi knelt on one knee at the entryway to change Ling Dang's shoes into slippers. After changing them, Ling Dang still wanted Liang Shi to carry her to the living room.

Liang Shi: "..."

Xu Qingzhu watched from behind them, quite puzzled. "You've already changed your shoes, why do you still need your auntie to carry you?"

Ling Dang buried her head in Liang Shi's neck and sniffed like a little puppy. "Auntie smells so nice."

As soon as she lifted her head, Xu Qingzhu noticed the red marks at the corner of her mouth. She pulled out a tissue and carefully wiped it off. "You two were sneaking food behind my back."

"Mm." Ling Dang held up one finger. "Just a little bit."

Even though an Alpha had good stamina, constantly carrying Ling Dang was still quite taxing.

After all, she was a five-year-old child—no matter what, she still weighed several dozen jin.¹

After putting her on the sofa, Liang Shi was a bit out of breath, and a thin layer of sweat had appeared on her forehead. Xu Qingzhu handed her a tissue.

As soon as Liang Shi lowered her head, she noticed a small red stain on the shoulder of her clothes.

The "evidence" that Ling Dang had left on her.

...

She smiled helplessly. "Sneaking food and not even knowing to wipe your mouth clean."

Ling Dang stuck her tongue out at her, then sat on the sofa to watch TV.

Footnotes:

¹ "Jin" (斤) - A Chinese unit of weight measurement. One jin equals 500 grams or approximately 1.1 pounds. "Several dozen jin" would mean the child weighs somewhere around 20-30+ kilograms (44-66+ pounds), which is typical for a five-year-old.

Chapter 65-6

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Liang Shi hadn't eaten much outside, and she hadn't actually packed a fast food meal for Xu Qingzhu either. She planned to cook something herself when she got back.

But then she discovered that Xu Qingzhu had been stewing a soup in the kitchen.

Waves of fragrant aroma were wafting out from the kitchen.

Liang Shi said in pleasant surprise, "Teacher Xu, you're really something. Your skills have improved."

Xu Qingzhu's face was expressionless. "A new chicken soup restaurant opened downstairs from the company. I got a semi-prepared kit to go."

Liang Shi's surprise visibly deflated.

"Where's my dinner?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi opened the refrigerator, unhurried. "Just about to make it."

The two of them were both in the kitchen. Xu Qingzhu had nothing to help with, so she just stood to the side and watched.

Liang Shi was about to tie her apron, reaching her hands behind her back, but couldn't manage to tie it no matter what. Xu Qingzhu couldn't stand watching anymore and reached out to help her.

Their fingers touched for an instant. Liang Shi quickly withdrew her hand, but after a moment said softly, "Your fingers are so cold."

"Don't you already know that?" Xu Qingzhu deftly tied it for her, then stood on tiptoe and casually placed her hand on the back of Liang Shi's neck. A tingly, numbing sensation immediately spread throughout her entire body.

In this world, because Alphas and Omegas had glands, their necks were more sensitive than other areas.

Especially the sides of the neck.

Xu Qingzhu's hands were cold. Touching Liang Shi's neck felt like touching a large heater, but she quickly withdrew her hand and didn't go too far.

Liang Shi turned to find her a hot water bottle.

But as she walked out of the kitchen, Xu Qingzhu noticed that the tips of her ears were particularly red.

Especially under the dim lighting, they appeared translucent and vividly colored.

It really made one want to go up and... give them a gentle bite.

Xu Qingzhu was startled by her own thought.

A perfectly normal person—how could she be like a vampire?

She shook her head, chasing away those romantic thoughts.

Dinner was simple. Liang Shi stir-fried one meat dish and one vegetable dish, paired with steamed milk flower rolls she had made herself.

Ling Dang was dying of hunger, but since she had eaten too much after school, she couldn't eat anything at all.

She could only watch them eat with longing eyes, swallowing her saliva.

It made the two adults feel rather embarrassed.

Yet they couldn't help but exchange a glance and smile.

Both seeing the helplessness and indulgence in each other's eyes.

After dinner, Ling Dang kept clinging to Xu Qingzhu, asking her to tell stories.

So Liang Shi went to clean up the kitchen.

Standing in the kitchen, her first thought was: The world is finally peaceful.

Dusk gathered, and night fell.

The moon hung gently in the sky, and the wind rustled through the treetops.

In the living room, Xu Qingzhu held Ling Dang and told her stories. In the kitchen, Liang Shi put all the dishes and utensils back in their places.

She could faintly hear Xu Qingzhu's cool voice.

When she told stories, her voice didn't have much inflection either.

But it was pleasant to listen to nonetheless.

Liang Shi benefited from Ling Dang's presence too, catching bits and pieces of the story.

By the time she came out of the kitchen, Ling Dang had already fallen asleep.

Xu Qingzhu gently patted her back, keeping her voice very soft as she continued telling the fairy tale.

Just when Liang Shi thought she was sound asleep, Ling Dang suddenly twitched her nose and turned over in Xu Qingzhu's arms, mumbling, "I want to sleep with you two tonight."

Liang Shi: "?"

She reasonably suspected this little friend was fake sleeping.

But Ling Dang's eyes were tightly shut, and after she finished speaking, her breathing gradually became long and even.

...

Xu Qingzhu turned her face to look at her, a smile playing at the corner of her lips.

Helplessly, Liang Shi once again carried her blanket and pillow upstairs. She took the opportunity to take a shower and change into pajamas.

When she set foot in that room on the second floor again, Liang Shi's feelings were complicated, though she didn't think too much about it.

Her mind was mostly still thinking about Su Mu, whom she had met today.

Trying to piece together a complete picture from the information.

Sheng Yu—whose child was she exactly?

If she were Sheng Qinglin's, she couldn't possibly be only this young.

Could it be that Su Yao remarried someone with the surname Sheng?

But in this Haizhou City, the surname Sheng wasn't common.

Especially since Su Yao had that tattoo on her body, showing just how deeply she loved Sheng Qinglin.

Liang Shi could basically conclude that Xu Qingzhu was the daughter of Su Yao and Sheng Qinglin.

Chapter 65-7

Xu Qingzhu bore some resemblance to Xu Qingya in appearance, and Ling Dang had even said at first glance that the woman looked a lot like her aunt.

There were almost no frontal photos of Sheng Qinglin online.

But it shouldn't be hard to see that in terms of looks, Xu Qingzhu had inherited her parents' best features.

Although Xu Qingya hadn't fully grown into her features yet, looking at her directly, she wasn't as beautiful as Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu's beauty came from deep within her bones. When she was timid, she had a timid kind of beauty; when she was confident, she had a bold and unrestrained beauty.

But in terms of her eyebrows, eyes, and facial features, it was as if she had been meticulously sculpted by Nüwa¹—completely flawless.

And the other half of Xu Qingzhu's beauty came from Su Yao, which was Su Mu.

But if Su Yao loved Sheng Qinglin that much, how could she not want her own daughter?

Could it be that she didn't know she had a daughter?

But... the child was born from her own body. How could she not know?

Besides, back then, anyone who paid even a little attention to the Sheng family could have guessed that the daughter who mysteriously appeared with Sheng Qinglin's older sister was actually hers.

Or could it be that Su Yao simply didn't care back then?

What kind of situation were she and Sheng Qinglin in at the time that would make her completely ignore the daughter she had carried for ten months?

Or perhaps after the daughter was born, the Sheng family forcibly took her away and wouldn't let her acknowledge the child?

But based on what Liang Shi had learned about the Sheng family from Xu Qingzhu, they weren't the kind of unreasonable people.

After all, having a child would ruin their own daughter's happiness.

Sheng Linlang's pregnancy out of wedlock had been mocked for a long time back then.

No matter how you looked at it, having the child stay with her mother would definitely be the best choice.

So what exactly was the hidden reason that made Su Yao abandon her daughter?

Just as Liang Shi was deep in thought, the door was suddenly pushed open. Xu Qingzhu stood in the doorway and said, "Teacher Liang, come downstairs and carry the child."

Only then did Liang Shi snap back to reality. The moment she saw Xu Qingzhu, her figure inexplicably overlapped with Su Mu's figure from today—even their bone structure was so similar.

It was just that Su Yao was older now and didn't have Xu Qingzhu's tall, upright posture.

Xu Qingzhu glanced at her indifferently and pressed her lips together. Even the position of her lip line was the same as Su Mu's.

Liang Shi was stunned.

But Xu Qingzhu asked, "Teacher Liang, who are you looking through me to see?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She completely came back to her senses and immediately shook her head. "I was just thinking about something."

Now wasn't the right time to let Xu Qingzhu know about all this.

Xu Qingzhu should still firmly believe that she was the daughter of Sheng Linlang and Xu Guangyao.

This system... was really detestable.

It seemed like it had given her 1.7 million, but actually getting it was far too difficult.

Wasn't this just making her be the villain?

If she told Xu Qingzhu now that everything the outside world said was true—that her parents weren't really her parents—she would probably be treated like a lunatic.

...

Forget it.

Liang Shi consoled herself. Just pretend she never had those millions.

Start fresh in this world.

What could be more precious than being alive?

Thinking this way, she put on a smile and asked gently, "Is Ling Dang sound asleep?"

"Mm." Xu Qingzhu said, "I can't carry her."

"Your stamina really isn't great." Liang Shi stood up and walked out, saying casually, "You should really exercise more from now on."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Her gaze immediately darkened. After a moment, she pressed her lips together and said, "It's fine as long as Teacher Liang has good stamina."

Liang Shi: "...?"

Liang Shi realized she had misspoken and immediately tried to salvage the situation. "Xu Qingzhu, that's not what I meant."

"I understand." Xu Qingzhu smiled. "Teacher Liang doesn't like to waste energy on small matters."

Liang Shi: "?"

"I also can't remember where I heard so many 'I can't do it's from.'² Xu Qingzhu pinched her earlobe. "Maybe I was just hearing things. What do you think, Teacher Liang?"

Liang Shi: "..."

"No..." Liang Shi felt like she had become too tongue-tied to speak. She looked at Xu Qingzhu. "Then..."

"No need to explain." Xu Qingzhu continued to smile, and even patted her shoulder. "Teacher Liang is very capable. Extremely capable."

Liang Shi: "?"

"Teacher Liang doesn't like to expend effort on trivial matters." Xu Qingzhu spoke in an earnest, heartfelt tone. "I understand."

Liang Shi: "..."

She was so flustered by these words that she couldn't help but lean forward, using her natural height advantage over Omegas to press Xu Qingzhu against the doorframe with an air of dominance. She ground out through clenched teeth, "Stop provoking me."

Footnotes:

¹ Nüwa (女娲) - A goddess in Chinese mythology who is credited with creating humanity. According to legend, she molded humans from yellow clay. Saying someone looks like they were "meticulously sculpted by Nüwa" is a way of describing someone as having perfect, divinely crafted features.

² This is a callback to earlier in the story when Liang Shi repeatedly told Xu Qingzhu "I can't do it" (我不行) regarding intimate matters, claiming she was incapable of marking with pheromones. Xu Qingzhu is now teasing her about those claims, implying that Liang Shi's "I can't" excuses were just that—excuses.